



Women having their children assessed for malnourishment at a clinic run by the charity Concern Worldwide in Mogadishu, Somalia.

U.S. Restores Some Global Health Aid With Big Grants

By STEPHANIE NOLEN

Over the past two months, the United States has made financial commitments that hint at a limited return to global health and humanitarian assistance partnerships, after the abrupt severing of many of those relationships a year and a half ago.

Last week, the State Department notified Congress that it would send \$600 million to Gavi, the organization that helps low-income countries buy essential childhood immunizations, a year after Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. withdrew American support.

It was the latest in a series of fi-

nancial commitments from the U.S. government to international organizations, working on issues such as hunger and tuberculosis, totaling nearly \$2 billion.

In most cases, these payments move money that had been appropriated by Congress but which had been stuck since the Trump administration took office in January 2025 and instituted a freeze on foreign aid.

It was not yet clear whether the disbursements represented a lasting shift, or how close any further commitments would bring the total to what the United States used to spend on aid and global health. People who have been part of talks with the State Department about this funding said that there

Unclear if \$2 Billion for Hunger and Disease Is a Lasting Shift

were at least two motivations behind the money flowing to resumed partnerships.

First, recent health threats including, most notably, the ballooning Ebola outbreak in the Democratic Republic of Congo, reinforced the need for funding multilateral agencies that work on global health security.

Second, with the Trump administration's dismantling of the United States Agency for Interna-

tional Development and absorption of a skeleton crew of its staff into the State Department, there was no longer the infrastructure or staff for the United States to move humanitarian assistance on this scale by itself, making these large international agencies necessary partners.

"What may be happening here is that reality is sinking in for decision makers," said Mark A. Green, who served as administrator of U.S.A.I.D. during President

Continued on Page A7

EBOLA The Bundibugyo virus stirs memories in the Ugandan town it was named for. **PAGE A4**

For Pastor and His Chatbot, Service to Congregation Never Sleeps

By ELI SASLOW

He had baptized them in his waders, counseled them through marital crisis and prayed at their hospital beds, and now Justin Lester stood in front of his congregation and asked for their trust again. "I can't lie," he said earlier this summer, as a few dozen people crowded into a backroom of the church. "What I'm about to show you might seem a bit out there."

Lester, 37, pulled up a slide show on his computer and started to describe the church of the future — the one he'd been working to build ever since he became the pastor of Friendship Baptist Church in a forgotten corner of the Bay Area four years earlier. He'd arrived in a staid place of fancy hats and traditional hymnals where some congregants still considered technology the mark of the beast. Now the church was using artificial intelligence to answer emails and plan Bible studies. It had doors equipped with facial recognition, podcasts with A.I.-generated biblical figures, and a robot dog named Theo who talked to children and recited sermons. Lester clicked to the next slide to show one of his latest innovations.

"I've been thinking a lot lately about how to duplicate myself," he said.

Lester pulled up a video of the newest member of his congregation as a few people in the audience started to record on their phones. It was his face on the screen, his voice, his mind. But it wasn't him. "That's my digital twin," he said.

In the last year, Lester and hun-



Images of Justin Lester that he has tested for social media video. His chatbot doesn't have video.

dreds of others have brought A.I. into its most human form yet by transferring their thoughts into data and building online replicas of themselves. The digital twins can answer in the real person's voice and apply their thinking on demand for anyone who wants to chat online or call. Some companies now build twins that sit on video calls for chief executives or manage projects while their owners are on vacation. Professors at

Clemson University deploy them to answer student questions at 2 a.m. A sex therapist uses her digital twin to offer individual counseling to hundreds of people at once. A man in Berlin created a twin after he was diagnosed with terminal cancer, so his wife could still talk to him before bed.

Lester cloned his voice and trained his digital twin using almost two million words of his sermons, podcasts, books, text mes-

sages and emails. For the last several months, it had been publicly available on his website and Facebook page for online chats or phone calls. It had learned to mimic his bent toward optimism, his obsession with the Green Bay Packers and his casual slang, but it did more than just regurgitate what he had already said. It mapped his thinking onto new conversations to provide advice

Continued on Page A12

Iran Mustered Its Proxies To Maximize Cost of War

Reasserting Influence With Militant Groups and Gaining Level of Coordination

By FARNAZ FASSIHI and NEIL MacFARQUHAR

A drone attack sent smoke billowing from a giant Saudi oil facility, the largest such plant in the world. Two gas tankers burst into flames at an Egyptian port near the Suez Canal, a crucial choke point in global trade. Fireballs erupted over Jordan as missiles flew toward a base housing U.S. personnel.

War has enveloped a widening circle of targets across the Middle East in recent days, as Iran and its phalanx of proxy militias have sought to strike at U.S. allies, roil global markets and push the United States to halt its campaign against the Islamic Republic.

The attacks are part of what two senior Iranian officials depicted as a step-by-step plan, devised in secret during a fleeting cease-fire this spring, that would use Iran's allies to escalate attacks if the United States intensified its assaults. The goal, the officials said, was to make the war as costly as possible for President Trump.

Mahdi Mohammadi, a senior adviser to Iran's chief negotiator, even crowded on social media about the strategy with the proxy forces, which are known in the region as the Axis of Resistance.

"The rules of the conflict are changing and being rewritten, we are creating new conditions and platforms in the war," Mr. Mohammadi said. "The fronts are multiplying from different directions in the region; they are of course co-

ordinated but act independently. A new axis of resistance is emerging with new players."

Iran and its allies have taken powerful blows since 2023, when the militant group Hamas attacked Israel. Recent events, however, have shown their capacity to regroup, stir chaos and gain Iran leverage.

Still, analysts do not consider the proxy forces — each with its own agenda — mere puppets of Tehran, though Iran's level of coordination and control varies among them.

The Houthis in Yemen, for instance, are seen as the most autonomous of the groups that make up the alliance. Hezbollah in Lebanon coordinates the most closely with Iran, while Shiite militias in Iraq are somewhere in the middle in the degree of their willingness to act as a direct arm of Iran.

But the groups still find common cause against the United States and Israel. During the short-lived cease-fire, Iranian generals covertly strategized with proxy militia commanders on how to expand the war and raise its cost for Washington, according to the two officials, both familiar with the planning as members of the Islamic Revolutionary Guards Corps, and both speaking anonymously to discuss sensitive internal deliberations.

Senior commanders from the

Continued on Page A6

Trump Polls Hit New Low? Not In His Universe.

By PETER BAKER

WASHINGTON — After a spate of bad polls earlier this summer, President Trump simply declared that they were not true. "MY REAL POLL NUMBERS ARE THE HIGHEST THEY HAVE EVER BEEN," he wrote on social media, using capital letters as if they would shout away any contrary data.

In fact, his real poll numbers are at or near the lowest they have ever been in some nonpartisan surveys. A flurry of new samples in recent days found that Mr. Trump is at the nadir of his presidency, with support from just around a third of Americans as a stalemated war in Iran and high gas prices take a political toll.

The latest surveys indicate that Mr. Trump is now all but the most unpopular second-term president at this stage of their tenure in the history of polling going back to the 1940s. The only exception is not one that would give Mr. Trump much solace: Richard M. Nixon had even less public support at this stage in his second term but at that point he was just days away from resigning over the Watergate scandal.

These kinds of poll numbers would throw a normal White House into panic mode, especially coming just three months before a midterm election. Someone might be fired. A speech might be written. A new set of policies might be devised. But Mr. Trump has never been a normal president, and he does not react to political circumstances in the same way his predecessors have. Through force of will and command over his MAGA base, he has traditionally played a weak hand strong.

"He's always going to project

Continued on Page A15



Senator Susan Collins backed Justice Brett M. Kavanaugh.

Vote That Led To End of Roe Plagues Collins

By LISA LERER and BETH REINHARD

Of the more than 10,000 votes cast by Senator Susan Collins of Maine, there is one that has shadowed her like no other as she runs for a sixth term.

On Oct. 6, 2018, Ms. Collins, one of only two Senate Republicans who support abortion rights, cast a deciding vote to confirm Brett M. Kavanaugh to the U.S. Supreme Court. Four years later, Justice Kavanaugh voted with the conservative majority to overturn Roe v. Wade, which had guaranteed a constitutional right to abortion for nearly half a century.

The vote cut against her well-cultivated reputation as a moderate Republican who is unafraid to break ranks. It also put her at odds with abortion rights activists, who had previously backed her campaigns, and with advocates for victims of sexual violence, who rallied behind a woman who accused Mr. Kavanaugh of sexual assault, an allegation he denied.

Now, Ms. Collins's support for Justice Kavanaugh has become a major issue in her first re-election campaign since Roe was overturned, a race that could swing control of the Senate. The 2018

Continued on Page A14



NATIONAL A10-15, 18

Cooling on Heat Safeguards

The Trump administration is seeking to roll back Biden-era rules to shield workers from scorching weather. **PAGE A10**

Wildfires Hit Washington State

Hundreds of structures were destroyed in Spokane County, and thousands of people were forced to evacuate. **PAGE A11**

INTERNATIONAL A4-9

Ukraine's Ousted Dronemaster

The former defense minister Mykhailo Fedorov, an advocate for automated warfare, says the country's tech-heavy strategy will persist. **PAGE A9**

Migrant Holdouts in Ceuta

A few hundred men are holed up on a seafloor, tired, hungry and refusing to go back to Morocco. **PAGE A8**

OBITUARIES B6

He Rattled Out Tony Soprano

Vincent Pastore, 80, played Salvatore Bonpensiero, a foot soldier turned F.B.I. informant on an acclaimed HBO series.



ARTS C1-6

A Shakespearean Westeros

A stage version of the "Game of Thrones" saga, with Michael Shaeffer, above, is opening in England. **PAGE C1**

Trump's Cultural Targets

Kim Sajet, former head of the National Portrait Gallery, knows what it's like to face White House attacks. **PAGE C1**

BUSINESS B1-5

Not All Fear an A.I. Bubble

As concern spreads over a potentially overinflated market, some tech investors in Silicon Valley are saying the excitement created by a bubble can drive new breakthroughs. **PAGE B1**

A Rush to Close Deals

In the Trump era, companies are seizing on what many say is perhaps the most favorable regulatory environment for businesses in years, compared with previous presidencies. **PAGE B1**

OPINION A16-17

Carlos Lozada **PAGE A17**



SPORTS D1-8

'Excited to Be a Dodger'

Tarik Skubal, who had hoped to bring postseason success to Detroit, now joins Los Angeles's loaded pitching staff after a blockbuster trade. **PAGE D2**

